

Session 4: Reflecting on the Introduction to Ephesians

Key Takeaways

- God's ultimate purpose and plan is to unify Heaven and Earth in the Messiah. This idea is the framework for the whole book of Ephesians.

Who Is Paul Addressing?

In Ephesians 1:1, Paul addresses his letter to "the holy ones" (Greek: *ἅγιοις*). This important term is usually translated "saints," which results in English readers missing the full theological significance of this term.

Holiness (Hebrew: *qadosh* / Greek: *hagios*) is first and foremost an attribute of God, defined as his unique, one-of-a-kind otherness by virtue of his status as the Creator and source of all reality.

Isaiah 6:3 Instructor's Translation

... "Holy, holy, holy is Yahweh God the mighty, the whole land is the fullness of his glory."

In the twin realms of Heaven and Earth, God has two parallel families of image-bearing representatives, the spiritual beings ("the host of heaven" in [Gen. 2:1](#)) and the human rulers on the land ([Gen. 1:26-28](#)). Both families are invited into God's presence to share in his holy status.

Israel as the Holy Ones

Israel is called to be a holy nation ([Exod. 19:6](#)). When they are faithful to the covenant and have access to God's presence in the temple, they become "holy ones." "I am Yahweh your God, and you will make yourselves holy, and you shall be holy ones (*ἅγιοι*) for I am a holy one (*ἅγιος*)" ([Lev. 11:44](#), [19:2](#), [20:7](#), [26](#); [Num. 15:40](#)).

Spiritual Beings as Holy Ones

Spiritual beings are also referred to as "holy ones" (*ἅγιοι*) in the Hebrew Bible ([Zech. 14:5](#); [Ps. 89:5-8](#); [Dan. 8:24](#)).

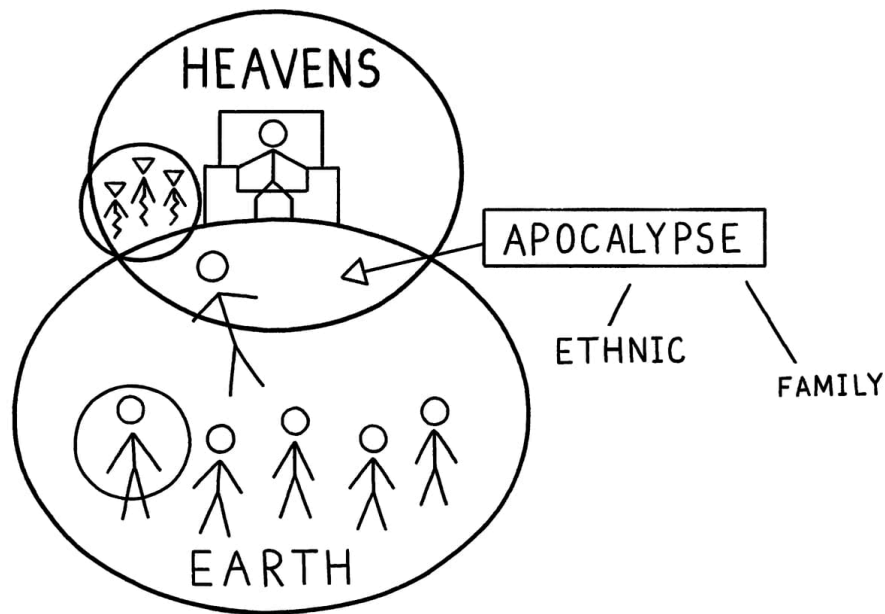
Psalms 89:5 Septuagint/LXX

The heavens will praise your wonders, Yahweh,
Even your faithfulness, in the assembly of the holy ones (*ἐκκλησίᾳ ἁγίων*).

Psalm 89:7 Septuagint/LXX

God is greatly feared in the council of his holy ones (ἀγίων) ...

Paul assigns the terminology of God's divine heavenly council to those who trust in the Messiah. Jesus the human Messiah has been exalted over the divine council to rule Heaven and Earth (Eph. 1:19-21), and that same status has been granted to his followers (Eph. 2:5-6).



The Space of the Heavens and the Earth. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Reflection Question

The apocalypse in Ephesians is about the reconciliation of all things, as well as the enthronement of humans with the Messiah. How can understanding these apocalypses as present realities change how you view your life in the here and now?